

ATTACK, VICTIMS, SUSPECTS: 4 SECTIONS

NATIONAL POST

VOL. 3 NO. 269    WEDNESDAY, SEPTEMBER 12, 2001    www.nationalpost.com

*‘No distinction between the terrorists who committed these acts and those who harboured them’*

AMERICA VOWS REVENGE AS

TERROR CLAIMS THOUSANDS

ATTACKS UNPRECEDENTED

IN U.S. HISTORY

Planes heavy with fuel chosen for maximum damage

*People are alive under the rubble, rescuers say*

By Chris Wattie

After the most catastrophic terrorist attack in history, the United States vowed last night to wreak vengeance on those responsible for thousands of deaths and the destruction of the most visible symbols of U.S. financial and military might yesterday. Shocked world leaders called the suicide assaults on New York’s World Trade Center and the Pentagon in Washington a declaration of war on civilization. George Bush, the U.S. President, said the United States will “hunt down and punish those responsible for these cowardly acts.”

“The search is underway for those who were behind these evil acts,” he said in a televised speech to the nation last night. “We will make no distinction between the terrorists who committed these acts and those who harboured them.”

No group took responsibility for the attacks, but suspicion quickly fell upon Osama bin Laden, an exiled Saudi dissident given asylum in Afghanistan. His followers were responsible for murderous assaults on two U.S. embassies in Africa and he is suspected of helping Egyptian fundamentalists plant a bomb in the World Trade Center in 1993.

Orrin Hatch, the top Republican on the U.S. Senate Judiciary Committee, said U.S. officials already have evidence to begin linking bin Laden to the attack.

Mr. Bush told Americans he watched the tragic images of hijacked airliners crashing into the buildings “with disbelief, sadness and a quiet, unyielding anger.”

The scale of the disaster, much of it witnessed by millions live on television, is almost incomprehensible.

In a co-ordinated attack, hijackers took over four wide-bodied commercial jets carrying 269 passengers and crew and flew three of them into their targets. Two slammed into the twin towers of the World Trade Center and the third roared into one side of the Pentagon. The fourth crashed in a field near Pittsburgh, failing to reach its target which was believed to be the White House, the U.S. Capitol or the presidential retreat at Camp David.

The terrorists employed a chilling logic in their choice of planes. Each had taken off from an eastern airport with a destination on the West Coast, meaning they were fully laden with aviation fuel, ensuring huge explosions.

There were no official estimates of the dead, but New York Police Department officials estimated it will be in the “thousands.”

The death toll of the plane passengers alone eclipsed the 168 deaths in the 1995 Oklahoma bombing, the previous worst terrorist attack in the United States.

John McCain, a senior Republican senator, called the attacks “an act of war.”

“None of us will ever forget this day,” Mr. Bush said.

*See ATTACKS on Page A17*



At 9:03 a.m. Eastern time, a commandeered airliner that had been scheduled to fly from Boston to Los Angeles is crashed into the south tower of the World Trade Center. Eighteen minutes earlier, the north tower had been struck.

Terror paralyzes financial markets

– ‘global recession is highly likely’

ECONOMY ALREADY FRAGILE

By Jacqueline Thorpe and Steve Maich

The devastating terrorist attacks on the United States could tip the already fragile world economy into recession, analysts say.

Stock markets around the world fell into panic selling yesterday, and as anxiety swept trading

floors in Europe and North America, investors flocked into such perceived safe havens as oil stocks, basic metals and government bonds.

Fears of a severe economic recession, or even war, prompted analysts to warn of an initial slump in growth, lower interest rates and soaring oil prices.

“I think we have certified for all practical purposes a recession as a result of this, with the market being as fragile as it is,” said Stan-

ley Nabi, a managing director at Credit Suisse Asset Management in New York.

“A full-blown global recession is highly likely,” said Sung Won Sohn, chief economist at Wells Fargo & Co. in Minneapolis.

Financial markets in New York, Chicago, Brazil and Mexico were closed shortly after the attacks.

In Tokyo, share prices fell below the psychologically important 10,000-point mark early this morning as investors fled the eq-

uities market. The Nikkei 225 index was down 3% or 303.61 points to 9,989.34 points during early trading.

At the New York Stock Exchange, officials suspended trading indefinitely. It will be the first time news has kept the exchange closed for two full days since the Great Depression.

“Nobody even knows when the markets are going to be open again,” said David Rosenberg, chief Canadian economist at Merrill Lynch in Toronto. “It could be tomorrow, it could be next week. The financial industry for all intents and purposes has been shut down.”

“Think of the talent that was in that building,” he added.

*See RECESSION on Page A18*

West’s

moral

failure

at root of

tragedy

Our holiday from history’s undertow has come to an end

Mark Steyn

You can understand why they’re jumping up and down in the streets of Lebanon and Palestine, jubilant in their victory. They have struck a mighty blow against the Great Satan, mightier than even the producers of far-fetched action-thrillers could conceive. They have driven a gaping wound into the heart of his military headquarters. They have ruptured the most famous skyline in the world, the glittering monument to his decadence. They have killed and maimed thousands of his subjects, live on TV. They have reduced the hated Bush to a pitiful presidential refugee, spending the day of infamy bounced to ever more remote military airports, from Florida to Louisiana to Nebraska, by a staff which obviously knows less about the power of symbolism than America’s enemies do.

And, for those on the receiving end, that “money shot,” as they call it in Hollywood — the smoking towers of the World Trade Center collapsing as easily as old chimneys at an abandoned paper mill — represents not just an awesome loss of life but a ghastly intelligence failure of the U.S. and a worse moral failure of the West generally.

There was a grim symmetry in the way this act of war interrupted the President at a grade school photo-op. The federal government has no constitutional responsibility for education: It is a state affair, delegated mostly to tiny municipal school boards. But one of Bill Clinton’s forlorn legacies is that the head of state and the Commander-in-Chief of the most powerful nation on Earth must fill his day with piffling initiatives designed to assuage the niggling discontents of pampered soccer moms and other preferred demographics: elementary school programs, prescription drug plans for seniors, “lock-boxes” for this and that, and a thousand other trivialities.

And so the President was reminded of his most awesome responsibility at a time when he was discharging his most footing. If you drive around Vermont and California, you spend a lot of time behind cars with smug bumper stickers calling for more funds to be diverted from defence to education, as this would prove what a caring society we are.

*See STEYN on Page A14*



70 cents plus applicable taxes